



CHAPTER XXX

RETURN TO MEXICO

1915 – 1921

Sarah spent over three years waiting for the revolution to subside so that she could return to her beloved home in Mexico. That opportunity came in the fall of 1915 when Anthony W. Ivins asked her to care for his home in Juarez after he was called to go to Salt Lake City as an Apostle. The revolution was still a threat when Sarah, along with Owen and Clarence, traveled by train to Juarez. The main reason for her desire to go there was so that Owen and Clarence could attend school at the Academy which, by this time, had reopened. Her intention was to eventually move back to Corrales. Owen's education had been interrupted for several years and he was twenty years old when he enrolled in school. The Juarez Academy was built by the L.D.S. Church and offered four years of high school training as well as special courses in music and in the commercial and agricultural fields along with other specialized courses. Owen and Clarence studied there for two years while Sarah boarded high school students and sold milk and butter to make a living. They lived in the Ivins home until 1918 when it was sold or donated to the Juarez Academy for more classroom space.

While Sarah was in Juarez, a family by the name of Telford bought milk from her. On one occasion Mrs. Telford had some extra money so she decided to pay in advance for the milk. She put the money in a handkerchief and sent her daughter, Linnie, over to the

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Lunts. She said, "I have some money that I want you to take to Sister Lunt. I don't owe her yet but, while I have this money on hand, I would like you to take it to her." When Sarah opened the door and Linnie held out the handkerchief to her, Sarah counted out the money, then lifted up her apron to wipe the tears from her eyes. She said, "Linnie, I owed a debt and my tithing and had only enough to pay one of them. This is exactly enough to pay them both." Sarah then told Linnie that she had always paid her tithing and, without fail, the money needed for other things had always come from some place. This made a lasting impression on the young girl.¹

Various outrages and tragedies were still occurring to the colonists in Mexican territory. Those who had escaped to the United States were grateful for their safety. However, the atrocities were not completely confined to Mexican soil. When the United States placed an embargo on guns and ammunition to Mexico, thereby closing Pancho Villa's much needed supply, he determined to initiate a reprisal drastic enough to threaten the lives of all "gringos" in Northern Chihuahua and to destroy the town of Columbus, New Mexico. Villa invaded the town the night of March 9, 1916, and killed ten civilians and eight army personnel, in spite of the fact that there was a garrison of American soldiers stationed there. They could not be convinced that the Mexicans would cross over the border. By daylight the American troops had assembled and nearly 350 of Villa's followers were killed, but stores and homes were looted and the town was practically destroyed by fire. In retaliation the United States sent an army of men, under the leadership of General John J. Pershing, into Mexico to capture Pancho Villa and attempt to settle the revolution.²

Knowing that the Mormon colonists were familiar with the surroundings in Mexico and were fluent in the language, the leaders asked for some of the men to go with the army as guides. President Ivins was supportive of this venture and encouraged some of the young men to accept this assignment because they had been treated so well by the Americans during the exodus. Edgerton was in Mexico working when he was approached to go as a guide, and he declined the invitation because he didn't want to quit his job, but Heaton did serve the army in this capacity and was one of the first five Mormon

scouts to accept this assignment. During the summer of 1916, Edgerton was working at the Rubio Ranch at San Miguelito when Mexican bandits arrived and took over the ranch. They took Edgerton as a prisoner and locked him up, taking all of his clothing. A few days later, on May 15, Lieutenant George S. Patton and a U. S. scouting party passed the ranch while on a scouting expedition, and the Villista snipers fired on them. During the skirmish with the Mexicans, Edgerton escaped. He directed the gunfire of the U. S. soldiers, as he knew where the bandits were hidden in the ranch buildings and behind the adobe walls. After the confrontation, Patton, who was carrying two pearl-handled six-shooters, came up to Edgerton and gave him one of the guns. Patton said, "Any son of a b---- that would stand between two lines of fire, like you did, needs a gun." Edgerton, hoping to see his brother, went back to the army camp, which was near Dublan. Two of the bandits were killed and the soldiers came into camp with the dead Mexicans on the running board of the car.³ Years later they realized it was the same Patton who became so famous as a general in World War II (Sylvan Lunt, Edgerton's son, still has the gun). Edgerton found Heaton at the army camp with his family, and he spent a few days visiting with them. Heaton served as a guide and scout until February 5, 1917, when he came back to the United States with General Pershing's army. After he was mustered out, he moved to Duncan, Arizona. The army was never able to find Pancho Villa.

Heaton was placed in unusually exciting and challenging situations. The following is one of the many stories he told about his experiences during this assignment:

In the fall of 1916 the American army was retreating back from the south. We camped close to the river bank below Las Cruces. The army was getting low on food so I told them that I thought, if we could go further back in the mountains, we could find some good cattle for camp meat. I spent about a half a day looking in the mountains. There was a canyon with plenty of water and grass and I found some wild cattle there--three-year-old steers, big and

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fat. They were real wild--the wildest kind. That's why the revolutionists had never been able to find them. I reported back to the mess sergeant and, the next day I took a little bunch of soldiers on horses with me. I placed the soldiers in the canyon and told them to wait until I drove the cattle down and then to fall in behind them. We had a terrible time because those soldiers just wouldn't mind. The cattle would start to run and they would just chase after them on those old army horses. The cattle, naturally, turned and ran in every direction just like quail when they chased them down and they saw our camp, and the soldiers couldn't outrun them. So I picked out a nice steer and made it past the critter, and I roped him by the horns and came down the hill by the camp. I brought him in on the run, his tongue hanging out and he was just a-bellering. I told the sergeant to have one of his men shoot him. Well, he shot the steer in the foot. There was another steer that was with that one and parted and ran over a steep hill toward the river. I knew I had to hurry, so I just jerked out my six-shooter and took a crack at this steer that I had roped, and it just happened that my shot cut the loop off of the rope just as I shot the steer dead. I didn't say a word, just whirled my horse and jerked the rope in the air and caught the end and made another loop as I rode off to catch up with the other steer. The steer went down a little pass right in the river. When he hit the deep water, he went clear under, and I was right behind him. I had a good saddle horse, so I could stay with him clear up to his shoulders. As he climbed up the bank on the other side of the river, shaking the water out of his ears, it gave me one chance. By throwing clear to the end of my rope to lasso him, I accidentally caught him by both horns.

We whirled back across the river, and I brought

him back to camp on the end of the rope. Instead of telling the soldiers to shoot him, this time I just pulled out my pistol, without saying anything, and dropped the steer for them to take care of. They came running up and said, 'Why did you shoot the rope in two on that other steer?' I said, 'Well, damn it, couldn't you see I was in a hurry and I did that to save time.' They wanted to know why I didn't shoot my rope in two again and I said, 'Can't you see, my rope's getting short? Out here you can't buy rope.'

That night it was said by one of the men while he was relating the incident, 'Did you see that Lunt scout shootin' them beef? Why that feller just pulled out that six-shooter and cut his rope off to save time. I'd sure hate to get him mad at me.'⁴

By this time the United States was involved in World War I. Only one of Sarah's sons, Owen, served in this war. However, some of Henry Lunt's grandchildren from Cedar City were called into the service of their country. Owen was inducted into the army October 1917 soon after his marriage to Velma Adell Jackson. Owen and Velma were married in El Paso September 7, 1917 and went to Salt Lake to be sealed and endowed on September 13. Velma went to Ogden to live with her family and Owen went to Fremont, Kansas to begin his army training.

Edgerton continued to travel into Mexico where he was able to get a job working in a mine. Although he was not a miner by trade, he knew how to manage and get along with the people. He had lived all his life in Mexico and knew the language well, so his boss sent him to the mine to supervise the work. They were mining molybdenum which was needed to make steel out of iron. This was an essential product for use in making weapons and machinery needed in the 1st World War. The ore was shipped into the United States on the railroad. Edgerton went to Pearson to try and get more horses to haul the ore as production had increased. There was a flu epidemic in this area at that time and, while there, he contracted the disease. Thinking

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it wasn't very serious he boarded the train, after buying the horses and went as far as Colonia Dublan where he stayed with some friends. He felt that he could continue on in a day or so, after he felt better, but he died there November 9, 1918, leaving a wife and three children. Because of the fear of the flu spreading, his friends buried him there in Dublan without even holding funeral services. There was no marker put on his grave. Edgerton was only 39 years old.⁵



George A., Thomas A. and Oscar G. Lunt
Henry and Annie's three sons (Photo from Mary Lou Lunt Cosper)

There had been no colonists living in Pacheco for six years, but the revolution was subsiding and a feeling of peace and safety was returning. The recovery of the colonies from the depression caused by ten years of revolution was slow and precarious. The ravages of war used up the teams that were used to raise the crops, and the amount of grain produced was very small at first. Prices were high. Added to this was the stagnation of business and lack of gainful employment. It was a time of general hardship. As the years went by, conditions slowly improved and a great many horses came from the United States. The farms again began to flourish and produce sufficient food for the people.

Sarah returned to Corrales on May 22, 1918, taking Clarence and Alma with her. To go back to the devastated home, where she had spent so many struggling but happy years, was a trial few women could endure. Her home had been dynamited and was a pile of rubble with only parts of the walls standing. Fences were gone that once enclosed fertile areas. There was no stock on the range to be looked after or bring in profit, but the natives gathered to greet her. A few homes of her friends had escaped the forest fires that swept the town. But, the once beautiful two-story church with its spires, to which she had contributed so much, was a skeleton with a leaky roof and glassless windows. Undaunted, she moved into the adobe home of her son, Heaton, which had not been destroyed. Alma and Clarence planted some crops. They refenced the fields, obtained more cows and Sarah resumed making cheese. She was happy again to once more be back where her husband and Aunt Ellen were buried. A few other families soon joined them and the Garcia colonists put in a small sawmill which was a great help to everyone, as it enabled the men to haul lumber to the valley to trade for flour and other household necessities.

Although the revolution calmed down, the Mexican government remained unstable. When the country kept getting new leaders, the peso became valueless. However, the silver dollar was always stable, and Sarah saved up forty silver dollars which she put in a baking powder can and kept it hidden in the flour bin. She informed her boys that this was for her burial expenses.

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In November, 1920 Sarah went to Duncan, Arizona for Thanksgiving and to see her boys again. They had a big family reunion at Edward's home. Heaton said, "For a long time she was determined that we were all going to come back to Mexico." She finally concluded that they would probably remain in Duncan. Owen moved there after getting out of the service, Parley came during the summer of 1919, and their half-brother, George, and his family came back to Duncan in the fall. Broughton, Edward and Heaton were already there. They took some family pictures while they were together.⁶



LUNTS
Thanksgiving 1920, Duncan, Arizona

The families of George A. and Kindness, Broughton and Mary, Parley and Pearl, Edward and Lettie, Heaton and Chloe, Owen and Velma, and Edgerton's wife, Anna May. Sarah Lunt sitting in center. Left to Right: (Sarah's children only) Sarah (sitting), Owen (behind Sarah with dark suit), Broughton (has hat on), Parley (in back by window), Edward (second from right), Heaton (on right end), and George (older man sitting in front – Annie's son).



EDGERTON LUNT
Born Feb. 5, 1879 – Died Nov. 9, 1918



SARAH LUNT'S BOYS
July 15, 1929 – Taken at Clifton, Arizona
Front Row (Left to Right): Clarence, Parley and Heaton
Back Row (Left to Right): Owen, Edward, Broughton and Alma

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Eventually five of the eight brothers, as well as Edgerton's wife, Anna May, purchased farms near Duncan with the intention of living there permanently. Owen's wife, Velma, was expecting a baby and was very excited about it, especially since she had already had a miscarriage (She is in the foregoing picture, standing on the back row, far right). In March 1921 the doctor in Lordsburg advised Velma to consult a doctor in El Paso where she could get better medical care. Her sister, Florence, who was also expecting a baby, went with her to El Paso where they found an apartment so they could stay there until the baby was born. During the night on April 7, about five weeks early, it was necessary for Velma to be taken to the hospital and the baby, Owen Raynal, was born by caesarean section the following day. It took a long time to get the baby to breathe. Velma seemed to be recovering from the chloroform but suddenly started having convulsions and died. The day after Velma's funeral, Florence delivered a two-month premature baby boy who lived only a few hours. Florence and her husband took Owen's baby to live with them. Owen visited them often, but they eventually moved away leaving him devastated. Later he remarried and intended to take young Raynal, who was going by the name of Payne, back to live with him but he was not able to get Florence to cooperate. However, when Raynal went on a mission he went by the name of Lunt.⁷

During the late summer of 1921, Sarah's health failed, and she suffered a long sick spell. In November four of her sons went to visit her, Broughton, Parley, Edward and Heaton. They tried to convince her to come to Duncan with them where she could get medical attention. She declined saying, "I want to stay right here. If it is the Lord's will that I should live, He can make me well here, and if my time to die has come, I want to die and be buried here." The boys went back home to Duncan and, after three weeks, Broughton received a telegram from President John T. Whetten with the news that Sarah was worse.

Heaton's wife, Chloe, Edward, and Broughton traveled back to Corrales to be with Sarah, knowing that she would not live very long. They arrived on Christmas Eve 1921, and stayed with her until she died on December 27, 1921. Alma and Clarence, along with

Clarence's wife, Lavetta were already living there with her. Clarence was made bishop of the Pacheco Ward in Oct. of that year.

Being a carpenter, Broughton made his mother a casket out of some of the boards on which she placed her cheese while it cured. Chloe and Lavetta lined the casket with white bleaching and the Johnson girls trimmed it with lace inside and out. Sarah was buried on December 29, on the left side of Henry. Ellen had been buried on the right side. The graves were located in the little Pacheco cemetery shaded on the north slope of a hill by young pines, junipers and wild roses.⁸



THE HEADSTONE in PACHECO CEMETERY
Henry Lunt, Ellen W. Lunt and Sarah L. Lunt (Photo by Sarah Lunt McGuire)

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2. Annie R. Johnson, *Heartbeats of Colonia Diaz*, (Salt Lake City, Utah: Publishers Press, 1972), p. 385.
3. LaCrita and Martin H. Lunt, "Edgerton Lunt History," Recorded by Martin H. Lunt, Salt LakeCity, Utah. Spelling on films: Cedar Ward--Egerton, Pacheco Ward--Hedgerton, and Ancestral File--Edgerton, p. 2.
4. Heaton Lunt, "Heaton Lunt Tapes," (Paraphrased) Transcribed by Mary Lou L. Cosper, 1985, from Carol L. Hill and Sarah L. McGuire, p. 92.
5. LaCrita and Martin H. Lunt, *op. cit.*, p. 3.
6. Heaton Lunt, *op. cit.*, p. 24.
7. Mary L. Nicholes, "Life History of Owen Lunt," (1992), p. 10.
8. Broughton Lunt, "Sarah Ann Lunt History," From Sarah L. McGuire file, p. 42.